

WORLD WAR II

The tank came of age during World War II, seeing service all over the world in all climates and all terrains. The success of the German attacks of 1939-40 was largely due to the mobility of their Panzer forces. Although individually many of their tanks were outclassed by the latest Allied vehicles, the Germans concentrated their tank formations into larger units that were supported by artillery and airpower in a combination that overwhelmed their enemies. By contrast, French and British tanks were often spread too thinly across the front, and many were too lightly armed for antitank warfare.

In North Africa, the British enjoyed great success against the Italians, but once the German forces began to arrive, offensives and counteroffensives by both sides saw the front line move hundreds of miles in both directions. The Soviet Union had roughly 22,600 tanks when the Germans invaded. Many were outdated, and around 20,500 were lost in 1941 alone. The invasion forced the Soviets to move entire factories hundreds of miles to the east, where they began producing tanks and equipment on an unprecedented scale. In Europe, the Allied advances of 1944-45 were made possible by the mobility of their tank forces. Tanks also fought in Italy, where their mobility was tested by the terrain, and in the Far East, where older, lighter Allied tanks remained viable against Japanese forces.

The Allies built over 180,000 tanks during the war, and many remained in service around the world for decades, serving alongside newer vehicles whose designs incorporated the lessons learned during the conflict.



△ **German war poster**

A German Army recruitment poster enjoins the Dutch: "For your honour and conscience! Fight Bolshevism. The Waffen-SS is calling you!"

Key events

- ▷ **September 1, 1939** German forces invade Poland. The Soviets invade on September 17, and Poland is defeated by October 6.
- ▷ **May 1940** The Battle of Arras. The experience of facing seemingly impenetrable British tanks spurs the development of the German Tiger.
- ▷ **April 1941** The Detroit Tank Arsenal delivers the first of 25,059 tanks to the US Army.
- ▷ **June 1941** Germany invades the Soviet Union. The next day, they encounter the T-34 for the first time.
- ▷ **November 1941** The first of over 12,000 British and American tanks supplied to the Soviet Union see action.
- ▷ **October 1942** The second Battle of El Alamein begins in Egypt. It marks the combat debut of the M4 Sherman.
- ▷ **July-August 1943** The Battle of Kursk is fought. The Soviets lose far more tanks than the Germans, but they gain the strategic initiative.



△ **Battle of Kursk**

Soviet infantry advance on a German position near Kursk in 1943. Their eventual victory was the beginning of the end of German ambitions in the east.

- ▷ **June 1944** On Saipan, the largest Japanese tank attack of the Pacific War is launched. Forty-four tanks take part, 12 survive.
- ▷ **April 1945** The invasion of Okinawa begins. Over 800 US tanks take part, reflecting how useful they have proven to be in the Pacific.

“Nikolayev and his loader Chernov **jumped** into the **burning machine**, **started** it, and sent it **right** into the **Tiger**. Both tanks **exploded** in the **collision**.”

RUSSIAN MINISTRY OF DEFENSE ARCHIVE, ON THE BATTLE OF KURSK

◁ **A US War Production Board poster** reminds manufacturers of their priorities during the war.